

Enclosure (1)

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INFORMATION REPORT

FORM 100-2 (1-1-58)

FROM

U.S. Naval Attaché, Rio

REPORT NO.

39-58

DATE

11 March 1958

offended because I don't doubt the authenticity of your photos but I need to hear from you. If you were going to make a flying saucer appear on a negative, how would you proceed? Comandante, I am an able photographer specialized in trick photography but not one would withstand close and accurate examination."

3. Brazilian Navy Stand. Immediately after the photographs of the flying saucer were publicized, the Brazilian Navy refused to make any official statement confirming or denying the incident. However, proofs from the original negatives were sent to the other armed forces and to the President via an officer-messenger who related the complete story. According to the press, the narration so impressed Mr. Rubitschek that he became convinced of the veracity of the happening.

On 24 February, three days after the photos were first published in the press, the Navy Ministry finally made an official statement: "With reference to the reports appearing in the press that the Navy is opposed to divulge the facts concerning the appearance of a strange object over Trindade Island, this Cabinet declares that such information has no basis. This Ministry has no motive to impede the release of photographs of the referred to object taken by Mr. Almir Barauna, who was at Trindade Island at the invitation of the Navy, and in the presence of a large number of the crew of ALMIRANTE SALDANHA from whose deck the photographs were taken. Clearly, this Ministry will not be able to make any pronouncement concerning the object seen because the photographs do not constitute sufficient proof for such purpose."

4. Statements of SALDANHA PORTUGAL. On the morning after the photos of the flying saucer were published in the press (February 22), the ALMIRANTE SALDANHA departed Rio to continue its mission in connection with the IGY. Two days later, however, the ship docked at Santos (February 24) for voyage repairs and this was the first chance that a newspaperman had an opportunity to interview officers and men aboard. The Assistant Naval Attaché was in Santos at this time in connection with the visit of ESCADANTO (Alcobaça Rio II 36-53 of 10 March) and had an opportunity to visit aboard. The commanding officer, Capitão-de-Mar-e-Guerra (CAPT) Jose Santos Saldanha da Gama, had not seen the object and was noncommittal. The executive officer also had not seen it but, arriving shortly thereafter, had formed the opinion that those on deck had seen it. The captain had reported that his secretary, a 12ER, had seen it but this officer then personally questioned avoided discussing the matter. Later, it was learned that the photographer was accompanied to the dark room by an officer who waited outside the door while Barauna developed the negatives alone.

At the time of the official visit of the commanding officer of ESCADANTO to ALMIRANTE SALDANHA, Captain Saldanha da Gama freely discussed the flying saucer and showed the original proofs to the callers but, again did not commit himself.

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5. Publicity. The press reports after the publication of the photographs covered a great deal of newspaper space for about a week, tending to prove or disprove the authenticity of Barauna's photographs. DIARIO CARIOCA reported that personnel of SALDANHA were under rigid orders of silence. O GLOBO published a story with photographs by photographer, Jean Vanzon, of flying saucers (china) taken at Cabo Frio.

Federal Deputy Sergio Magalhães sent a note to the Navy Ministry on 27 February protesting the Navy's failure to secure sworn statements of witnesses. "For the first time in flying saucer history, the phenomenon was attended by large numbers of persons belonging to a military force which give these latest photographs an official stamp. Threats to national security require greater official attention and action," said the Deputy. In the middle of all the publicity, other "flying saucer" sighting reports came out including a naval officer who saw a flying saucer a month before sighting from SALDANHA off the coast of Espirito Santo. CO and crew of ATA TRIDENTE saw flying saucer several days before SALDANHA sighting but kept information secret.

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Preparing Officer's Comments:

1. Most flying saucer stories are not worth wasting much time or effort, but this story apparently substantiated by official Navy photographs taken in the presence of large number of Navy personnel under closely controlled and almost ideal circumstances should have absolutely proved the existence of an unidentified flying object. Unfortunately, further investigation provided only frustration at every turning. A number of Brazilian Navy officers profess to believe the story implicitly but whether they have more information than we is unknown.

2. There appear to be only two explanations for this peculiar incident:

(a) Some overwhelming power has told the Brazilian Navy not to officially verify this incident (which they should easily be able to do, if it occurred) nor to deny it (which they should easily be able to do, if it is a fake). I personally do not believe that anyone has told the Brazilian Navy to keep quiet about it because there has been no hint of such suppression in either Brazilian or U.S. circles; and also because I doubt their control of the individual officers and that is good enough to hold the line.

(b) The whole thing is a fake publicity stunt put on by a crooked photographer and the Brazilian Navy fell for it. This seems like the most likely considering Brazilian's love for sensationalism and gossip, their well known propensity for never letting the truth stand in the way of a good story, and general bureaucratic inefficiency.

3. In addition, the photographs furnished by the Brazilian Navy are unconvincing. Details of the land are extremely sharp but the disc is hazy and has little contrast and shows no shadow effect. It also appears that the object was inserted in photograph 2 compared to 1 and 3. Also the papers have mentioned extremely high velocities and there appears to be no lateral blurring as would occur with any reasonable shutter speed.

4. It is the reporting officer's private opinion that a flying saucer sighting would be unlikely at the very barren island of Trindade, as everyone knows Martians are extremely comfort loving creatures.

Prepared and forwarded:

M. SUNDERLAND
CAPT, USN